



From left to right (standing) 20th Century Fox Co-chairman Jim Gianopulos, line producer Tabrez Noorani, Q&A writer Vikas Swarup, Studios CEO Vijay Singh; from left to right (sitting) Director Danny Boyle, producer Christian Colson, co-director Loveleen Tandon, and two young boys from the film.

Coverstory **SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE**

LITTLE BIG WINNER

By Kaveree Bamzai

Freida Pinto is busy being wooed by the world's finest designers, when she's not prepping for the *Tonight Show* or scheduling a doctor's appointment for a sudden flu. Dev Patel is getting ready to work with Manoj Night Shyamalan, when he is not enjoying the pleasures of stardom at 19, flirting on the BAFTA red carpet with Sharon Stone among them. Anil Kapoor is grappling with the idea of acting as Dr Karna, a yogi who speaks five languages in a forthcoming Fox Network show, when he is not playing Oscar celebrity photographer for *People* magazine, and doing what Cate Blanchett did last year, hosting an Oscar trivia show on CNN. Even the little seen Madhur Mittal is busy fielding free champagne at Dubai restaurants. First class upgrades, celebrity talk show appearances, *Vanity Fair* photo shoots, invites to Diane Von Furstenberg's pre-Oscar picnic. Life's a whirl for *Slumdog Millionaire*'s underdogs.

It mirrors the story of the film, made for \$15 million, almost sent straight to DVD when Warner Independent Pictures shot it down, but saved by Peter Rice of Fox

Searchlight, and now having made \$138 million and counting. It's a film made by an art house British director, a man best known so far for the very gritty *Trainspotting*, adapted from a book by IFS officer Vikas Swarup, with a crew that was almost completely Indian, from first assistant director Raj Acharya who'd shot slums before in S. Shankar's *Nayak* to the steadicam operator Suneil Khandpur whom Boyle borrowed from Anurag Kashyap after watching his work in *Black Friday*.

The film has swept almost every award show in the run-up to 10 Oscars nominations, from four Golden Globes to seven BAFTA wins. It's almost a shoo-in for Best Picture with the predominantly white, middle-class, 65-plus members of the 5,200-strong Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences expected to vote for it. For Danny Boyle, till now considered a left field, thoroughly maverick director, it has meant an immediate catapult into the A-list of Hollywood's most wanted directors. It's a tribute to the star of the film, Mumbai, and its slum children, with their whitest teeth and